

Explaining Accusative Case Marking on Locative Arguments in South Bolivian Quechua

In South Bolivian Quechua (ISO 639-3: quh), a nominative–accusative language, locative arguments can surface with either spatial case markers (e.g., *-man* ‘allative’, *-manta* ‘ablative’, *-pi* ‘locative’) or the canonical accusative suffix *-ta* (Lastra, 1968). We identify three core patterns. First, in some contexts, only spatial case is grammatical (1); second, in others, only accusative is acceptable (2); and third, both options are possible but yield subtle discourse distinctions (3). This distributional variation presents a morphosyntactic puzzle: when and why is the accusative marker licensed on locative arguments, given its prototypical association with direct objects?

We propose three interacting constraints to explain this variation. 1) The Proto-Patient Constraint: accusative marking is permitted on locative arguments when they instantiate key proto-patient properties (Dowty, 1991), such as being an incremental theme or undergoing a change of state. As shown in (2a), the location being traversed (e.g., a street) can receive accusative marking, reflecting its affected role. 2) The Agreement Constraint: when verbs or verbal morphology encode directionality (e.g., ‘enter’ in (4), or directional suffixes like *-mu* in (5)), spatial case is required to satisfy lexical semantic agreement; accusative is blocked. 3) The Competition Constraint: if another noun is already marked with accusative, a second accusative-marked locative argument is disallowed to avoid argument structure ambiguity (see (6-7)).

In contexts where both case options are possible, we propose a discourse-pragmatic account. Spatial case marking foregrounds the locative information as focal or newly introduced, while accusative marking packages the entire event as discourse-new (Lambrecht, 1994; Givón, 1984). Consultant judgments confirm this: when asked “What is happening in Isidro’s town?”, the answer favored accusative on the location (3a), introducing the full event; when asked “Where is it raining?”, consultants preferred spatial marking (3b), focalizing the location.

This case alternation aligns with typologically attested patterns where accusative marking extends to non-core arguments in constrained contexts (Malchukov & Spencer, 2012). In Slavic and Germanic languages, accusative is used for directional locatives, while Japanese allows accusative-marked locations in resultative constructions (Takahashi, 2011; Levin & Rappaport Hovav, 1994). These data support semantic accounts linking accusative to affectedness (Hopper & Thompson, 1980). Our findings show that case assignment in SBQ is sensitive not only to event and argument structure but also to discourse status, reinforcing growing evidence for the interaction of syntax, semantics, and pragmatics in differential case marking systems.

References

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Examples The data were elicited from two SBQ speakers (one of them is the second author of the present study).

- (1) a. *Tata Isidru Buffalo-ta ripu-n
Mister Isidru Buffalo-ACC move-3SG.PRS
b. Tata Isidru Buffalo-man ripu-n
Mister Isidru Buffalo-ALL move-3SG.PRS
'Mister Isidro moves to Buffalo.'
- (2) a. Tata Isdru yan-ta pasa-sha-n
Mister Isidru street-ACC cross-PROSS-3SG.PST
b. *Tata Isdru yan-pi pasa-sha-n
Mister Isidru street-LOC cross-PROSS-3SG.PST
'Mister Isidru was crossing the street.'
- (3) a. Tata Isidru-q llajta-n-ta para-sha-n.
Mister Isidru-GEN town-3SG.POSS-ACC rain-PROG-3SG.PRS
b. Tata Isidru-q llajta-n-pi para-sha-n.
Mister Isidru-GEN town-3SG.POSS-LOC rain-PROG-3SG.PRS
'It is raining in Mister Isidro's town.'
- (4) a. *Tata Isidru wasi-ta yayku-n
Mister Isidru house-ACC enter-3SG.PST
b. Tata Isidru wasi-man yayku-n
Mister Isidru house-ALL enter-3SG.PST
'Mister Isidru entered the house.'
- (5) a. *chaqra-ta papa-ta apa-mu-sha-n
corp.field-ACC potato-ACC take-DIR-PROG-3SG.PRS
b. chaqra-manta papa-ta apa-mu-sha-n
corp.field-ABL potato-ACC take-DIR-PROG-3SG.PRS
'She or he is taking potato from the crop field.'
- (6) a. Unáy t'impu-chi-ytawan papá manka-man kacha-yu-ni
long.time.ACC boil-CAUS-NOMLZ potato.ACC pot-ALL send-PFV-1SG.NF
'After making boil for a long time, I put the potato in the pot.'
b. Unáy t'impu-chi-ytawan papá manka-ta kacha-yu-ni
long.time.ACC boil-CAUS-NOMLZ potato.ACC pot-ACC send-PFV-1SG.NF
'After making boil for a long time, I put the potato and the pot (in someplace).'
- (7) a. Tata Isidru ch'uñu-ta yaku-pi chullu-chi-n
Mister Isidru dried.potato-ACC water-*loc* soak-CAUS-3SG.NF
b. *Tata Isidru ch'uñu-ta yaku-ta chullu-chi-n
Mister Isidru dried.potato-ACC water-*acc* soak-CAUS-3SG.NF
'Mister Isidru soaks the dried potato in water.'